

different story—the all-black keyboard with touches of blue backlighting looks good.

The ASUS F3JM is very much on the lines of the V6000J. The brushed aluminum finish is great to touch, and the laptop feels quite sturdy.

## Ergonomics

For a performance machine, ergonomics are of prime importance—these laptops will be used for extended periods of time. The HP Pavilion dv8216TX takes the crown here—it's very comfortable to use. The touchpad

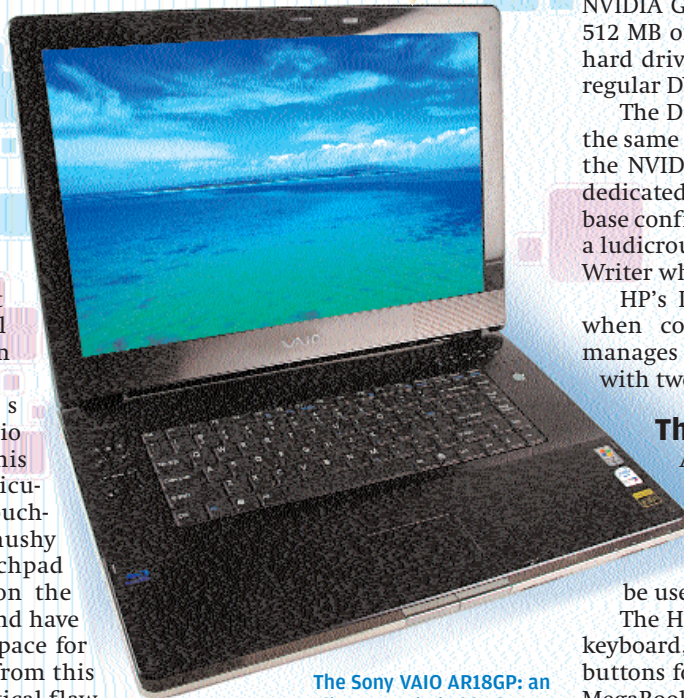
is very good, and comfortably placed towards the right. Scroll notches on the touchpad let you scroll through long spreadsheets and Web pages. The keyboard has a proper numeric keypad on the right side. The tactile feel could have been better, though.

Nothing's perfect—the Sony VAIO AR18GP proves this with its rather ridiculous placement of touchpad buttons and a mushy keyboard. The touchpad buttons are lined on the edges of the body, and have very little contact space for any comfort. Apart from this small but rather critical flaw, everything else is in right place. Sony could also have made much better use of the space by providing a full keyboard.

The Latitude D820 is a typical no-nonsense laptop from Dell, and everything is exactly in place for providing the best comfort. Toshiba's Qosimo F20 had nothing to point a finger at; however, the laptop does tend to get hot, making the cooling fan work overtime.

## Specifications

One look at the Sony AR18GP's specifications will leave you gasping for breath. Harboring the fastest Core Duo 2.16 GHz, 1 GB of RAM,



The Sony VAIO AR18GP: an elite assassin in black!

and the GeForce Go 7600 GT 256 MB, the configuration rocks! If that's not satisfactory enough, it comes with 160 GB of storage in the RAID 0 configuration—a big boost to hard drive performance. To top it all, this was the only machine with a Blu-ray disc writer. A superb, bright 17-inch high definition-ready display (HD 1080P) completes the VAIO's stunning specs—the DVD movies we watched on this screen were memorable experiences!

Next in line was the ASUS F3JM with a 2 GHz processor, an insane 2 GB of memory, and an NVIDIA GeForce Go 7600 display adapter with 512 MB of dedicated memory. A single 120 GB hard drive provides storage, topped off with a regular DVD-Writer.

The Dell Latitude D820 manages to cram in the same 2 GHz processor, 1 GB of memory, and the NVIDIA Quadro NVS 120, with 256 MB of dedicated memory and a 100 GB hard drive. The base configuration bundles just a combo drive—a ludicrous decision, but you can opt for a DVD-Writer when configuring the machine online.

HP's DV8216 TX is slightly underpowered when compared to these giants, but still manages to hold its ground. This laptop came with two 80 GB drives.

## The Frills

Apart from the on-paper specifications, the Sony VAIO AR18GP comes with a 1.3 megapixel Web camera, instant media player capabilities, and inbuilt Bluetooth. The camera's feed can also be used as a screensaver—quite interesting!

The HP dv8216TX comes with a full-fledged keyboard, a dedicated "calc" button, and media buttons for quick play. The ASUS F3JM and MSI MegaBook M660 were the other notebooks that came with 1.3 megapixel Web cameras built into the top lid. Toshiba's Qosimo was the only one with an inbuilt TV-Tuner and media playing capabilities without booting into the OS. Memory card readers seem to have percolated into all notebooks, and these performance champions are no exception.

## Performance

The Sony AR18GP delivered unusually high performance—the scores it returned matched some of the best scores we've seen on Desktop PCs. Its score of 27 in Business Winstone is simply great—very few laptops ever make beyond the 25 mark. The Dell D820 did come within striking distance of the Sony, with a score of 26.2, but it lacks the critical fire power—the RAID hard drive. The ASUS F3JM also came pretty close to the Sony.

The Business Winstone benchmark consists of regularly-used applications, and it's a perfect benchmark to judge the real-life performance of laptops. Sony scoring high on this benchmark clearly indicates its performance benefits in a normal usage scenario.

In the video encoding test, the Sony completed the job in just 112 seconds—that's seriously fast, and speaks about the processor's number-crunching abilities. The Dell D820 wasn't far behind, taking 118

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